Corpus: witchcraft and incantations (כשפים-ולחשים/)

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Created 2026-10-21/23 by Round 3, run 6 (curated-translation-candidates.md, "Round 3 plan"). The corpus holds texts
against witchcraft and the rites of the exorcist: how a Mesopotamian who believed himself bewitched named his fear,
went to law with the witch before the gods, and burned her in effigy. The first text is the great anti-witchcraft
ceremony **Maqlû**; later candidates (Šurpu, the CMAwRo rituals, the Lamaštu incantations, Hittite elimination
rituals) would join it.

Why these texts (both purposes, guidelines §1)

- **The Bible.** Exod 22:17 מְכַשֵּׁפָה לֹא תְחַיֶּה names the Akkadian *kaššāptu* with its own cognate; Deut 18:10–11
  lists the practitioners; 2 Kgs 9:22 and Nah 3:4 accuse Jezebel and Nineveh of *kešāfîm*; Isa 47:9–14 mocks Babylon's
  sorceries that the fire will consume; Ezek 13:17–23 attacks the women who "hunt souls"; Lev 14 and 16 purify with
  cedar, sprinkling and a substitute that carries sin away; Num 5 makes words dissolve in water. Maqlû is the fullest
  ancient script of the world those laws forbid.
- **The ancient mind.** Maqlû shows what a Babylonian feared (the neighbour's evil eye, a stolen hem or footprint, an
  image buried with a corpse), how he imagined justice (a night court before the gods, the witch as defendant, the
  sentence executed by fire), and how a body was cleansed and handed back to life at dawn.

The texts

Project	Text	Base text	Lines	Status
1-מקלו/	**Maqlû** ("Burning"), Tablets I–VIII and the Ritual Tablet (Standard Babylonian, 1st millennium BCE; manuscripts from Nineveh, Assur, Huzirina, Sippar, Nippur, Babylon, Uruk)	eBL Mag/1/1 (ed. T. Abusch, rev. D. Schwemer; translation Abusch): ../sources/eBL/Maqlu-I/ … Maqlu-RT/	1,595 eBL labels (I 152, II 231, III 202, IV 155, V 181, VI 161, VII 198, VIII 133, RT 182)	**done (first draft), 2026-10-23**: all lines, three passes per tablet, verified (maqlu_tools.py verify --strict), 567 parallels rows; print stub ../-הדפסה/כשפים ולחשים/1-מקלו.rtl.md

How the parts relate

The eight incantation tablets are the words of one ceremony; the Ritual Tablet (RT) prescribes the acts that go with
each incantation, quoting its first line. Every tablet ends with the first line of the next (a catch-line), and
Tablet VIII recalls incipits of the earlier tablets. Reading order: I–VIII, then RT (or RT beside each incantation it
quotes). Night (I–V: the witch's figurines are burned before Nuska and Girra, then the fire is quenched) gives way to
morning (VI–VIII: fumigation, washing, the substitute, the sunrise prayers).

Tools and files

- maqlu_tools.py (in this folder): fill, pars, lem (lemma candidates from ORACC cmawro: eBL lemmatized only
  Tablet I), norm, incipits, lines, verify [--strict], build, grep [--all]. See its docstring and ../tools.md.
- renderings.md binds every translator; translator-brief.md is the common brief.
- parallels-index.md: generated from the annotated **הקבלה** bullets by build_parallels_index.py.